

PUBLIC SAFETY

DPS seeks vehicle in fatal La Ward hit-and-run

JAKOB GURLEY

JACKSON COUNTY — Texas Department of Public Safety investigators are asking for the public's help identifying a vehicle involved in a fatal hit-and-run Monday on State Highway 172 near La Ward.

The crash occurred in Jackson County, just south of the Wharton County line.

According to DPS, troopers responded after a man was struck while outside a travel trailer. The victim was identified as Benjamin Lee Faulk of New Braunfels.

A preliminary investigation determined Faulk was changing a damaged tire on the trailer when he was struck by a passing vehicle. He was pronounced dead at the scene at approximately 12:56 p.m.

The vehicle that struck Faulk left the scene and has not been identified.

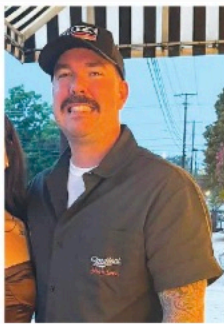
Investigators are also seeking information about two other vehicles that were seen pulling onto the northbound shoulder about 100 yards from the crash site shortly after the collision. Both vehicles later left the area.

DPS investigators believe the occupants may have witnessed the crash or have information that could help identify the vehicle involved.

Anyone who was traveling on SH 172 near La Ward around noon Monday, witnessed the crash or has dashcam, surveillance or other video footage from the area is encouraged to contact law enforcement.

The investigation remains ongoing.

Jakob Gurley is a multimedia journalist with the Victoria Advocate. He can be reached at jakob.gurley@icad.com.



Benjamin Lee Faulk of New Braunfels was killed after he was struck by a passing vehicle while changing a damaged tire on a travel trailer along State Highway 172 near La Ward, according to the Texas Department of Public Safety. (Courtesy Photo)

PATRIOT DAY



FDNY Capt. Michael Dugan hangs an American flag from a light pole in front of what is left of the World Trade Center after it was destroyed in a terrorist attack on Sept. 11, 2001. (Andrew Savulich/New York Daily News)

PAIN, TRAUMA AND GRATITUDE

Those who were there remember 9/11

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ROCCO PARASCANDOLA,
REBECCA WHITE,
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When terrorists destroyed the World Trade Center, hundreds of thousands of first responders, workers and NYC residents raced to the towers. They bore witness to horror, devastation and heroism.

Their lives were forever altered.

Now, 25 years later, they remember that day and the years that passed with a mix of pain, trauma and profound gratitude as well.

Beauty amidst devastation

For NYPD Emergency Service Unit officers Gregory Welch and Everald Taylor, every day after 9/11 has been a blessing and a curse of sorts — a blessing to be still alive and on the job, and a curse because of those they lost along the way. The pair are just two of the four current ESU members who were working when hijacked planes tore into the World Trade Center and killed nearly 3,000 people, including 14 of their fellow ESU officers.

"I try to live my life one day at a time," Taylor, 58, said about his approach to life and the job he still loves. "Stop and smell the roses and appreciate what I have no matter how little it is or how big it may be."

Taylor doesn't like to dwell on the past. But he can't forget it, either.

Even now, when he catches a glimpse of the Twin Towers in an old movie or in someone's photo album, the memories of how the city was changed forever come rushing back.

"Look at how beautiful they were. Look at how long they stood. I just have that wow feeling of how the city used to be," he said. "That was New York. That was New York City. It's different now."

There are few people left in the unit who can tell the stories that Welch and Taylor can tell.

Welch tells new members of ESU not to be afraid of fear.

"These young men are just as brave and selfless," Welch said. "But they're different. The generation is different. Even though you're scared, you need to go in and do the right thing because nobody else is going to do it."

He also tells them to find the joy — a lesson he learned from 9/11.

"What can we take out of 9/11? The best thing was 9/12," Welch remembered. "We came together, and everybody in the country took up the job of supporting New York."

"It was a beautiful thing to experience," he recalled. "There were American flags everywhere you looked. I wasn't alone. The whole city, the whole country was on board. We saw it. And it was amazing."

Illness and hope

Cheryl Hall, a retired Con Edison worker who helped bring back power to Ground Zero after the terror attacks, isn't worrying about the 25th anniversary of 9/11. She's impatiently waiting for another anniversary — one she'll reach in 2027.

"Once I reach my five-year mark, I'll be considered cancer-free," Hall told the Daily News. She was diagnosed with the 9/11-related uterine cancer in 2021 and underwent surgery in 2022.

In 2023, due in part to her efforts, cancers of the uterus were officially added to the ever-evolving list of 9/11 illnesses, and she was among at least 50 women who worked as responders to receive full coverage for past and future treatments.

"I'm just glad that it was caught and it was added," Hall said. "Maybe I was used so that people can get the help they needed."

SEE 9/11, A3

GOVERNMENT

Victoria approves \$241.7M budget, lower tax rate

ALEXANDRA PASKHAVER

With little public participation, the Victoria City Council unanimously approved the city's fiscal year 2027 budget, the Victoria Sales Tax Corporation budget and a lower property tax rate during a brief special meeting Tuesday.

The 19-minute meeting drew few residents, with rows of seats in the council chamber remaining empty during public hearings on the budget and tax rate.

Resident John Swanson was among those who spoke, calling for greater transparency regarding the cost and work of the city's fire services.

"I don't think we can afford this fire department," Swanson said. "I would like to get ... an annual fire marshal's report that tells me how many fires they actually put out. There is one big fire that we had at Uncle Mike's ... where is the fire report? The fire marshal ... I don't want to disparage the guy. It's the opposite. It's the work that's being done, [it] isn't the people."

The council approved the fiscal year 2027 budget without additional public comment.

The \$241.7 million budget includes several changes from the version presented Aug. 4. Capital project funding increased by \$2 million for the 148th project, while \$2 million was removed from venue tax funding because of reductions to the Community Center project budget.

The council also unanimously approved a property tax rate of \$0.4538 per \$100 of property valuation for the 2026 tax year, a decrease of \$0.0232 from the current rate.

The new rate is expected to generate about \$28.38 million, approximately \$711,558 less than the previous year.

Before approving the rate, council members amended language in the ordinance after Assistant City Manager Gilbert Reyna explained that its original wording did not meet legal requirements.

The required language states: "The tax rate will

The general fund increased by \$80,000 to cover landscaping costs, while the economic development fund added \$25,000 for community relations.

Council members also unanimously approved the fiscal year 2026-27 budget for the Victoria Sales Tax Corporation without public comment.

The largest expenditure increases were for utility and public safety projects, which increased by about \$2.15 million and \$1.11 million, respectively.

Spending on street and drainage projects decreased by about \$2.36 million, or 11%, compared with the previous year. The projected ending fund balance decreased by about \$1.03 million, or 12.8%, while expected revenue increased by \$90,000, or 0.9%.

Tax rate approved

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SEE BUDGET, A3



Victoria City Council members met to approve the city's fiscal year 2027 budget and property tax rate. (File Photo)

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A mother's love shines through on 9/11

■ WEATHER

TODAY
Hot and humid with a stay-at-home storm



TONIGHT
Mostly cloudy, warm and humid



97

78

VIEWPOINTS, A6

■ GAS PRICES

Sam's Club

9202 North Navarro Street, Victoria

As of 12:40 p.m. Thursday
Prices subject to change

REGULAR:
\$3.79

PREMIUM:
\$4.37

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